ENGL 263: POETRY AND DRAMA

THE CONTENT OF THE COURSE IS MADE UP OF THE FOLLOWING:

A: SIX SELECTED POEMS

B: ONE PLAY (DRAMA)

DETAILS OF COURSE CONTENT

- POETRY: A: *THINGS FALL APART* BY KOFI KINATA
- B: *SHE WALKS IN BEAUTY* BY LORD BYRON
- C: *THE SECOND COMING* BY WILLIAM BUTLER YEATS
- D: *WHEN I CONSIDER HOW MY LIGHT IS SPENT* BY JOHN MILTON
- E: *DEATH IN THE DAWN* BY WOLE SOYINKA
- F: *NIGHT RAIN* BY JOHN PEPPER CLARK
- DRAMA*: MUCH ADO ABOUT NOTHING* BY WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE

INTRODUCTION: WHAT IS LITERATURE? AND WHAT IS POETRY

- Literature is a subject that is interested in the study of creative works. These works could be fictional(created through imagination) or they could be biographical(true to life and are divided into autobiographical and biographical works). We study these works to educate ourselves about life, about the culture of other people and our own culture, to draw moral lessons, to entertain ourselves, to learn how language is used creatively, to sharpen our skills in criticism, and to develop our creative skills. Though literature studies creative works, these works are written by humans who lived in particular societies and in our world and therefore take the raw material of their works from life and hence, there is a closer link between literature and life.

GENRES OF LITERATURE

- Literature is generally divided into three genres: poetry, drama and prose. Poetry is the oldest and the most condensed, drama is the next in terms of age and prose is the youngest. Literature can exist in the written form and is therefore referred to as written literature and it can also exist in the oral form and is therefore referred as oral literature or orature. The basic ingredient common to both written and oral literature is the idea of creativity when it comes to the use of language. Language is like a paint to the creative writer or composer. Language is used to creatively paint the images and imagery that a writer or composer wants to paint for our mental consumption and to prick our senses. Depending on which genre the writer/composer is into, we can have poets, dramatists/playwrights, and novelists.

What is poetry?

- Poetry can tentatively be defined as a form of art that has a message and uses a specific medium to express that message. The medium of expression could be language, performance or performance together with language. A poem is therefore a unique way of expressing an emotion, giving an opinion or telling a story. Poetry is an art form whose pleasure is derived mainly from sound.
- We have two main types of poetry: the narrative poetry and the lyrical poetry
- Narrative poetry as the name denotes is a kind of poetry that is used to tell or narrate a story. Narrative poems include the epics and the ballads. Because of their narrative nature, they tend to be long and extansive but their language is verse and not prose. Example of epics include the epic of Sundiata, *The Rape of the Lock* by John Pope, *Paradise Lost by John* Milton, etc. We also have primary epics, secondary epics and mock epics

What is poetry?

- Lyrical poetry, unlike the narrative one, is usually short, highly rhythmic and is used to express the feelings, musings or emotions of a speaker/ persona in a poem. The word lyrical is derived from the name of a musical instrument called the lyre because of the close association between the lyre and this kind of poetry. The sonnet, the ode, the elegy, the dirge, the epithalamium, the aubade, the villanelle, the haiku etc are all examples of lyrical poetry.
- A third type of poetry that is less known is the dramatic poem. It possesses the elements of surprise, dialogue and the use of poetic features. *My Last Duchess* by Robert Browning is a clear example of the dramatic poem.

FEATURES OF POETRY

- Every poem has all or most of the following features:
- Poet versus persona/personae
- Title
- Subject matter
- Theme
- Structure
- Language(diction, imagery)
- Setting
- tone

Features of poetry

- Atmosphere
- Connotative/ denotative meanings

DETAILS ON FEATURES OF POETRY

- Every written poem has an author/ composer/ or the one who wrote it. That person who composed the poem is different from what we technically referred to as the persona(e) of the poem. The persona is the speaking voice in the poem. In analyzing the poem and for the sake of objectivity, we normally refer to the persona as the one who does or says most of the things in the poem. We always want to take away the author from the poem and concentrate on the context, language, imagery, structure and sound pattern in the poem. By so doing, we remain objective and faithful to what the text of the poem says and not concentrate on the biography of the author in order to elucidate meaning on the poem. In traditional oral poetry, it is possible to come across compositions that have collective or communal ownership. In the written case, it is always individual ownership that is involved.

DETAILS ON FEATURES OF POETRY

- Most poems have titles. These titles serve as a window to the content or meaning of the poem. Sometimes, the way a poem is titled throws a lot of meaning into the content of the poem. In other words, there could be a direct link between the meaning of a poem and its title. However, sometimes, some writers intentionally use titles that are ironical, paradoxical, exaggerated, etc in order to mislead unsuspecting readers and to create a special meaning. Sometimes, such tricky titles lead to the addition of creative flair to the meaning of a poem. For example, *The Beautyful Ones Are Not Yet Born* by Ayi Kwei Armah and *The Joys of Motherhood* by Buchi Emecheta are some of the crafty titles that can easily mislead unsuspecting readers

DETAILS ON FEATURES OF POETRY

- A poem's subject matter is what the poem is all about. If the poem is written on war, we say the subject matter is on war or it is about war. If it is a poem on death, we say the subject matter is death. However, there is a close relationship between subject matter and theme. If the poem talks about war and the subject matter is war, then the theme refers to the specific general moral lesson about war that the poem talked about. From the subject matter we derive the theme and whereas the subject matter can be stated in a word, the theme is usually a clause or a sentence. Thus, there is a specific reason why we write on war, love, death, unfaithfulness, etc. That specific reason is what usually constitutes the theme of the poem

DETAILS ON FEATURES OF POETRY

- Structure in poetry is an important and interesting feature. It is interesting because it is not every poem that is written in two or three or four stanzas. A single line can constitute a whole poem. At the same time, there are some types of poems that have fixed structures. Such poems include the sonnet, the villanelle, the haiku, etc. In looking at the structure of the poem, we are interested in the division of the poem into stanzas, how many lines per stanza, we are interested in the mid-rhymes and end rhymes, we are interested in any rhyming scheme that we can establish, we are interested in types of lines used(run-on lines/end stopped lines), the use caesura etc and how they all contribute to the overall meaning of the poem.

DETAILS ON FEATURES OF POETRY

- Language is the paint and brush of the poet and therefore, words used in the poem cannot be glossed over. Language in poetry is normally divided into two sections for detailed analysis(diction/imagery). The choice of words used in the poem is normally referred to as diction and the literary devices or figures of speech used constitute the imagery. In analyzing these two aspects of the poem, we usually concentrate on how appropriate the diction or imagery is to the subject matter and theme, how they contribute to the meaning of the poem and the beauty of the language used, how technical, ordinary, archaic they are and why. It is not enough to identify an image and move on. Its meaning and contribution to the overall meaning of the poem and the beauty of language used must be explained as well.

DETAILS ON FEATURES OF POETRY

- Setting is also an important component in poetry. It simply refers to the place where the poem is set or written. We can therefore talk about historical and geographical settings. These two elements talk about time and place and these elements are important in poetry analysis. They help understand the context of the literary piece. Tone also is the attitude of the persona towards the subject matter based on the choice of words. The tone could be ironical, harsh, critical, satiric, passionate, detached, etc

WHAT IS VERSE?

- ***Verse*** is the language of poetry. Verse is any arrangement of words to produce a regular effect through metre, rhythm, and or rhyme. Consequently, all poetry is written or composed in verse, but not all poems have the attributes of metre, rhythm and rhyme as well.
- ***Blank verse*** has all the features of poetry except, in most cases, rhyme. In most of the Shakespearean plays, almost all the noble characters speak in blank verse whereas villains and common characters speak in prose. Blank verse is usually in iambic pentameter, the nearest pattern to human speech.

WHAT IS VERSE

- ***Free verse*** is a kind of arrangement of words that does not give much attention to metre or rhyme, or even rhythm. Its distinctive feature as poetry derives from the sequence or iteration of ideas than anything else; it is therefore very much like prose arranged in shorter lengths to give the visual shape or structure as that of the verse. Metre, rhythm, and rhyme are therefore incidental to free verse. The poetry of T. S. Eliot and most other 20th century poets is largely free verse.
- ***Rhyme***: This is the sameness of the sounds of words (particularly their ends) that are not related in meaning. Thus the endings of the words have similar sounds though the words are not synonyms. Rhyme was one of the distinguishing features of poetry up to the beginning of the 20th century; but it is now, along with other things, no more a requirement of poetry.

WHAT IS VERSE?

- Rhyme could be true or false. A true rhyme is a rhyme involving two words with the same (or different) vowel arrangement in spelling but have the same vowel sound in pronunciation; e.g, *sound* and *found*, *bough* and *bow*. A false rhyme is one in which two words with the same vowel arrangement in spelling have different pronunciation; e.g *bow* (weapon) and *bow* (to bend).
- ***Rhythm***: rhythm is the movement of words through a regular succession of strong and weak accents that gives indication of “pulse” or “beat” in poetry or prose. Rhythm is more important to poetry than it is to prose. Rhythm engages the ear through a regular flow of feet and thereby enables the mind to take in definite stretches of thought and feelings expressed in the lines. A break in rhythm nearly always implies a break in thought and feeling and calls for a new adjustment or reaction from the reader or listener.

WHAT IS VERSE?

- ***Metre***: This is the word used in describing the fixed foot-pattern in a whole poem. It simply means measure. It is the metre which gives the rhythmic shape of the whole poem. Some poems have rigid or regular metre in which the rhythmic shape of the first stanza is repeated throughout the whole poem; others have irregular metres in which the rhythmic shape varies from stanza to stanza. There is therefore a close link between music and poetry and the example of the ballad and the lyric attest to this.

THE SONNET

- It is a poem that has a fixed form: fourteen lines. The composer of sonnets is often referred to as a sonneteer. The sonnet is the most popular example of the lyric. The etymology of the word sonnet can be traced to the Italian word ‘sonnetto,’ which means a sound or a song. Obviously, considering its musical nature, it is the meaning of ‘a song’ that fits the word. The sonnet started as a literary composition in Italy and was made popular by Francesco Petrarch and hence the name Petrarchan sonnet. The Petrarchan sonnet is normally divided into an octave and a sestet. The rhyming scheme for the octave is normally constant while the rhyming scheme for that of the sestet remains flexible and changeable. For the octave, we normally have ***abba***, ***abba*** as its rhyming scheme. The sestet can take the form of ***cd, cd, cd***, or ***cde, cde*** or a different combination altogether. There is usually a volta in between the octave and the sestet in which there is always a change in the line of argument presented in the poem

THE SONNET

- It was much later that the sonnet moved to England and English writers experimented with the sonnet for some time. Shakespeare wrote a lot of sonnets and he also helped in establishing the form of what later became known as the Shakespearean, English or Elizabethan sonnet. Instead of composing it in an octave and a sestet, the English sonnet was rather composed in quatrains and a couplet. The quatrains present the argument and the couplet sums up or resolves the problem stated in the poem. The rhyming scheme for the typical Shakespearean sonnet is normally ***abab, cdcd, efef, gg***. The typical Shakespearean sonnet is usually composed in the iambic pentameter.

THE SONNET

- Much later, another version of the sonnet was developed in England by another group of authors. This third version was known as the Spenserian sonnet which was also composed in quatrains and a couplet but with a different rhyming scheme. The rhyming scheme for the Spenserian sonnet is usually ***abab, bcbc, cdcd, ff.***

“DEATH IN THE DAWN” BY WOLE SOYINKA

- Akinwande Oluwole Babatunde Soyinka was born in Abeokuta, South-west Nigeria on July 13, 1934. He is a Yoruba by tribe and has written works in poetry, drama, prose and essays as well. In all, his novels are about three(*The Interpreters*, *Season of Anomy* and his most recent novel which was published in September 2021 and titled *Chronicles from the Land of the Happiest People on Earth.* He won the Nobel Prize in literature in 1986 and has gone on to win Europe Theatre Prize and other awards. His poetry has been widely anthologized and most of his plays staged all over the world. His prose works are also studied in universities all over the world.

Soyinka as a dramatist

- Soyinka is best known as a dramatist and has published many plays since he started writing. *The Swamp Dwellers* and *The Lion and the Jewel* (a light comedy), which were performed in Ibadan in 1958 and 1959 and were published in 1963. Later satirical comedies are *The Trial of Brother Jero* (performed in 1960, publ. 1963) with its sequel, *Jero's Metamorphosis* (performed 1974, publ. 1973), *A Dance of the Forests* (performed 1960, publ.1963), *Kongi's Harvest* (performed 1965, publ. 1967) and *Madmen and Specialists* (performed 1970, publ. 1971). Among Soyinka's serious philosophic plays are (apart from "*The Swamp Dwellers*") *The Strong Breed* (performed 1966, publ. 1963), *The Road* (1965) and *Death and the King's Horseman* (performed 1976, publ. 1975). In *The Bacchae of Euripides* (1973), he has rewritten the Bacchae for the African stage and in *Opera Wonyosi* (performed 1977, publ. 1981), he bases himself on John Gay's *Beggar's Opera* and Brecht's *The Threepenny Opera*. Soyinka's other dramatic works are *A Play of Giants* (1984) and *Requiem for a Futurologist* (1985), *King Baabu* (2002) and The *Beatification of Area Boy*(1995).

STYLE AND PREFERRED THEMES

- Soyinka's themes are eclectic and diverse: they include racial discrimination, man's inhumanity to man, political corruption, social injustice, death, etc. He uses elaborate imagery in the form of satire, antithesis, dramatic monologue, biblical allusions, etc to enlighten, entertain and celebrate different topical issues. He is generally regarded as a difficult poet and hence there is no enthusiasm in exploring the full range of his poetic art. K. E. Senanu and T. Vincent write that " Soyinka's writings are sophisticated" while D. I. Nwoga says that Soyinka's poetry is characterised by "obscure allusions," "turgidity" and an "abstract and esoteric language".

THEMES IN DEATH IN THE DAWN BY WOLE SOYINKA

- The first theme in *Death in the Dawn* is the inevitability of death. No matter what we do as humans, we cannot avoid death. The inevitability of death as a theme is refereed to in his other poems such as *Post Mortem*, *Death in the Dawn*, *Prisoner* and *Season*
- The next theme in the poem is the uncertainties about life. To bring this theme into fruition, the author uses devices such as antithesis in the title, irony and contrast in other sections of the poem to establish this theme.
- Finally, the last theme one can talk about in the poem is myth and ritual or the theme of superstition. Africans as we are, the belief in spiritual things that cannot be scientifically proven is with us.

ANALYSIS

- ***Death in the Dawn by Soyinka***
- *Traveller, you must set out*
  At dawn. And wipe your feet upon
  The dog-nose wetness of earth.
- This is the first stanza of this dramatic monologue in which the persona addresses the reader as a *Traveller* and life in general as a journey that we all go through in life. In this journey, death is unavoidable and nothing is certain. The title contains an antithesis in the combination of death and dawn. Dawn symbolizes new beginning, hope, and has a positive connotation. But death occurs in a dawn thus nullifying all the positive connotations of dawn as a symbol of hope and new beginning. This makes life uncertain and it also makes death inevitable. The persona recommends travelling at dawn when the earth is still wet like “the dog-nose wetness”. This is a powerful metaphor that is African in its origin and aptly compares the dampness of the earth at dawn to the nose of a dog. The nose of the dog is usually wet just like the earth is usually damp at dawn.

ANALYSIS

Let sunrise quench your lamps, and watch
Faint brush pricklings in the sky light
Cottoned feet to break the early earthworm
On the hoe. Now shadows stretch with sap
Not twighlight's death and sad prostration
This soft kindling, soft receding breeds
Racing joys and apprehensions for
A naked day, burdened hulks retract,
Stoop to the mist in faceless throng
To wake the silent markets - swift, mute
Processions on grey byways…

ANALYSIS

The second stanza is a an eleven line stanza in which the persona advises the reader to set off for the journey early enough. It is the sunrise that will replace the lamp of the traveler in the middle of the journey. The traveller must set off at the time when farmers and traders set off early in the morning to the farm and market respectively. "*Faint brush pricklings in the sky light*" refers to the early morning sun rays and the shadows that are created by the early morning sun rays are full of vitality and stand up straight in contrast to the twilight's shadows that lie prostrate on the ground. Again, while the morning shadows will grow darker and stronger and point to life, the twilight shadows point to disappearance in the night. Thus contrast is created here between life and death, telling us how intertwined the two are. *Racing joys and apprehensions for the naked day* is also used here to highlight the uncertainties about life: the naked day is the source of both joys and apprehensions. The "grey" image which represents death in *Post Mortem* and other poems has been referred to in this poem again.

ANALYSIS

On this
Counterpane, it was -
Sudden winter at the death
Of dawn's lone trumpeter, cascades
Of white feather-flakes, but it proved
A futile rite. Propitiation sped
Grimly on, before.

In this third stanza of the poem, reference is made to the killing of a white cock by a car. The feathers of the cock after it has been hit by the car are described as "*sudden winter*" and the cock itself personified as "*dawn's lone trumpeter*". The falling feathers are further described as " *cascades of white-feather –flakes*". The killing of the cock is supposed to be a propitiatory rites to the god of road, ogun and which is supposed to save the life of the driver. However, we are told that the rite is a futile one and will not achieve the desired effect. This is what raises the theme of myth and ritual or the theme of superstition. We believe in gods, in ancestors and in the role of the fowl as a propitiatory animal to the gods and ancestors. The use of alliteration as contained in the fifth and sixth lines of this stanza is interesting. It captures the lightness of the feathers and the ease which they are flying and landing on the ground as if it is a cascade of water.

ANALYSIS

The right foot for joy, the left, dread
And the mother prayed, Child
May you never walk
When the road waits, famished.

In this fourth stanza, the theme of superstition or rites and myth is continued. The belief is that the road has a god in the form of ogun, and when it is famished(personified), it can easily cause accidents. It is also believed that by stepping out with the right foot, one can avoid bad luck whereas stepping out with the left foot first brings bad luck. Every mother's prayer is that the son or daughter should never travel when the road is famished.

ANALYSIS

Traveller you must set forth
At dawn.
I promise marvels of the holy hour
Presages as the white cock's flapped
Perverse impalement - as who would dare
The wrathful wings of man's Progression…

In this fifth stanza, the persona continues to address the reader as *Traveller* and this traveller must set out at dawn. The white cock is knocked by the car and the persona warns of the marvels (wonders) of travelling at dawn as the white cock is knocked dead by the car. The angry wings(wheels) of man's progression actually refers to the car. The speed at which it is moving is compared to a car flying and metaphorically, this progression also refers to scientific and technological progress in life. Life is not only short but progress in man's life is also moving at a very fast pace. Ellipsis is used in the last line of this stanza create meaning that is unsaid in the poem in this stanza

ANALYSIS

But such another Wraith! Brother,
Silenced in the startled hug of
Your invention — is this mocked grimace
This closed contortion – I?

In this last stanza, the persona refers to another death. We just witnessed the death of the cock, and now there is another death. This death is rather ironic: " *a Brother is silenced in the startled hug of his own invention.*" The car created through man's invention to provide comfort and progress is the source of this death. This contrast between the good and bad side of the car helps in highlighting the theme of uncertainty in the poem. The car is personified by *hugging* this Brother. It is again personified by being *startled*: the car itself is surprised about the sudden death of the driver. The sudden but painful expression of death on the face of the driver is captured here. The last line of the stanza ends with a rhetorical question by the persona. The question accentuates the universal nature of death: no human can escape it. It is the turn of the driver today, but it could be the turn of the persona tomorrow.

STRUCTURE AND LANGUAGE

The poem is divided into six stanzas of varying length. It is written in free verse. The language is appropriate to the subject matter of death and it depicts the futility of man's effort aimed at avoiding death. All the rites and myths or the superstitions about death are unable to help man enjoy life forever. Apart from using the appropriate diction, Soyinka also deployed varied imagery in this poem: the title contains an antithesis, there are also instances of personification, metaphor, symbolism, irony, contrast, alliteration,etc that have all been used to delineate the theme of death and the uncertainties that go with life on this earth.

She Walks in Beauty

By Lord Byron (George Gordon, 1788-1824)

She walks in beauty, like the night

Of cloudless climes and starry skies;

And all that's best of dark and bright

Meet in her aspect and her eyes;

Thus mellowed to that tender light

Which heaven to gaudy day denies.

She Walks in Beauty

By Lord Byron (George Gordon)

One shade the more, one ray the less,

Had half impaired the nameless grace

Which waves in every raven tress,

Or softly lightens o'er her face;

Where thoughts serenely sweet express,

How pure, how dear their dwelling-place.

She Walks in Beauty

By Lord Byron (George Gordon)

And on that cheek, and o'er that brow,

So soft, so calm, yet eloquent,

The smiles that win, the tints that glow,

But tell of days in goodness spent,

A mind at peace with all below,

A heart whose love is innocent!

Who Is Lord Byron?

Lord Byron—George Gordon Byron, 6th Baron Byron to be precise—is one of English literature's most infamous figures. He was part of the British Romantic poets, in particular the second generation (along with Percy Bysshe Shelley and John Keats). This particular poem was published in his collection *Hebrew Melodies* (1815), which was originally intended to be set to music (which perhaps is reflected in the simplicity of the poem's meter).

What is Romanticism?

Romanticism is an intellectual orientation that characterized many works of literature, painting, music, architecture, criticism, and historiography in Western civilization over a period from the late 18th to the mid-19th century. Romanticism can be seen as a rejection of the precepts of order, calm, harmony, balance, idealization, and rationality that typified Classicism in general and late 18th-century Neoclassicism in particular. It was also to some extent a reaction against the Enlightenment and against 18th-century rationalism and physical materialism in general. Romanticism emphasized the individual, the subjective, the irrational, the imaginative, the personal, the spontaneous, the emotional, the visionary, and the transcendental.

What is Romanticism?

Among the characteristic attitudes of Romanticism were the following: a deepened appreciation of the beauties of nature; a general exaltation of emotion over reason and of the senses over intellect; a turning in upon the self and a heightened examination of human personality and its moods and mental potentialities; a preoccupation with the genius, the hero, and the exceptional figure in general and a focus on his or her passions and inner struggles; a new view of the artist as a supremely individual creator, whose creative spirit is more important than strict adherence to formal rules and traditional procedures; an emphasis upon imagination as a gateway to transcendent experience and spiritual truth.

ANALYSIS

This is an eighteen line poem that is written in three stanzas. It has has an alternating rhyming scheme in the form of *ababab*, *cdcdcd*, and *efefef*. The subject matter is on beauty, the beauty of an unnamed lady. In this poem, contrasting features such as darkness and light, day and night, inner beauty and physical beauty, emotions and thought are combined to strike a balance and achieve a harmony that is unique and rare in nature. This may explain why the rhyming scheme keeps alternating in order to accommodate these contrasting features in the poem. The language (diction and imagery) is simple as reflected in most Romantic poems. The poem is highly lyrical. The innocence of the lady, the purity of her heart, the serene nature of her thoughts are all displayed on her face.

Analysis

Themes of the poem include the idea that true beauty is a blend of both the physical and the inner beauty. That it is always possible to strike a delicate balance between contrasting features as is the case of the unnamed beauty in the poem.

Analysis

The and imagery are both simple and appropriate for the subject matter. Literary devices such as simile, personification and other sound devices have been used in the poem to achieve harmony. The most outstanding expression in the poem is “She walks in beauty.” This is an expression that gives a unique meaning to the entire poem. It tells us that the lady does not look beautiful or walks beautifully. She is the true definition of a perfect balance between inner beauty and outer beauty.

Night Rain by J. P. Clark

What time of night it is

I do not know

Except that like some fish

Doped out of the deep

I have bobbed up bellywise

From stream of sleep

And no cocks crow.

It is drumming hard here

Night Rain by J. P. Clark

It is drumming hard here

And I suppose everywhere

Droning with insistent ardour upon

Our roof thatch and shed

And thro' sheaves slit open

To lightning and rafters

Night Rain by J. P. Clark

I cannot quite make out overhead

Great water drops are dribbling

Falling like orange or mango

Fruits showered forth in the wind

Or perhaps I should say so

Much like beads I could in prayer tell

Them on string as they break

In wooden bowls and earthenware

Night Rain by J. P. Clark

Mother is busy now deploying

About our roomlet and floor.

Although it is so dark

I know her practiced step as

She moves her bins, bags and vats

Out of the run of water

That like ants gain possession

Of the floor. Do not tremble then

Night Rain by J. P. Clark

But turns, brothers, turn upon your side

Of the loosening mats

To where the others lie.

We have drunk tonight of a spell

Deeper than the owl's or bat's

That wet of wings may not fly

Bedraggled up on the iroko, they stand

Emptied of hearts, and

Night Rain by J. P. Clark

Therefore will not stir, no, not

Even at dawn for then

They must scurry in to hide.

So let us roll over on our back

And again roll to the beat

Of drumming all over the land

And under its ample soothing hand

Joined to that of the sea

Night Rain by J. P. Clark

- We will settle to sleep of the innocent and free.

Analysis

John Pepper Clark is a Nigerian poet. He has composed other poems such as *Streamside Exchange, Ibadan, Olokun, Night Rain and Abiku*.

Night Rain is a one stanza poem with 47 lines. It is written in free verse and the setting is a typical rural setting in Africa. In the poem, the persona who is a child recounts the story of a heavy rain fall at dawn. The room in in which the person and his brothers as well as their mother are living in is just a roomlet. This alone depicts their poor status in life. But besides that, the thatch of the room leaks and as the rain keeps drumming on the thatch, the persona can see the mother in the darkness going about and placing containers at strategic points where the roof is leaking. This is to prevent the water leaking into the room from spreading all over the floor in the room.

Analysis

Thus, while the mother is up from sleep and is trying to prevent water from leaking into the floor of the room where the children are sleeping, the persona and his brothers are fast asleep. As children, they have no worries and responsibilities and can afford to sleep soundly. Therefore, the persona would advise the brothers to just roll over to the other end of the mat and continue to sleep. The persona and his brothers are compared to a doped fish or wet bats and owls that cannot fly due to the fact that they are drenched and wet. The poem starts on a note of despair and ends on a note of optimism.

Analysis

Imagery such as *doped fish* and *bedraggled* owls and bats are apt in the poem. They describe the deep spell of sleep in which the persona and his brothers find themselves. One other thing that one needs to take note of is the use of verbs in the "_ing" form in order to denote action and the continuous falling of the rain. Verbs such as *drumming, droning, dribbling, falling, deploying, filing, loosening, soothing*, etc have all been used in the poem. The themes such the rugged nature of rural life (theme of poverty)and the helplessness of man in front of natural forces are highlighted in the poem.

Things Fall Apart by Kofi Kinata (Fante Version)

Oh oh aah ooh ah ah Call me Kofi Kinaata
[Verse 1]
Friday chapel all night Saturday na ye wo club no mo
Yɛ le yɛ more things Women, shoker bugu cup no mo
Ade ye ship na ɔde Bible no baa yɛ no
Nkrɔfo sie nara nso di schnapp no bɛ yɛ
Nti girls na wo duro chapel a wo kɔ yɛ no
Bra bɛ hwɛ, wɔn nso a na club no wo kɔ yi

Things Fall Apart by Kofi Kinata

[Chorus]
Nti Nyame som paa na yɛ le som yi a?
Bisa wo nua, ne bisa woa so wo ho
Nyame som paa na yɛ le som yi a?
Ma Jehovafo no rebaa ne ɛrɛguani
Nti Nyame som paa na yɛ le som yi a?
Nae ɛtale obi nu kun dɛ plaster yi
Nyame som paa na yɛ le som yi a?
Hwɛ so ma me a ɛleku no agye ne dan yi

Things Fall Apart by Kofi Kinata

[Verse 2]
Me sie atamuda paa…
Ɛda a Nyame bɛba physical
Sɛ won consider pa dia…
Anhwɛ na heaven wɛn ya nipa
Cos, nokware no wɔ hɔ Nso asɔfo yi w’ntumi w’nka
Sikasɛm ne nti chapel ahiafoɔ ntumi w’mba
W’ntumi w’mba oo
Ɛho mpo na ndi the things fall apart
Ɛka a wo sie anointed men touch
Chapel yi w’wɔ schools paa
Nso members yi w’ntumi w’nkɔ bi

Things Fall Apart by Kofi Kinata

[Chorus]
Nti εyε Nyame som paa na yε le som yi a?
Bisa wo nua, ne bisa woa so wo ho
Nyame som paa na yε le som yi a?
W’ma agyanka na asεm ayε mɔbɔ yi
Nti Nyame som paa na yε le som yi a?
Wo nua fom wo a, atumi fa nkyε no yi
Nyame som paa na yε le som yi a?
Don Nana Amu ade na wo de ahyε bitters yi, asey

Things Fall Apart by Kofi Kinata

- Verse 3]
  Hwɛboo sofo yegyi woa wo ho
  Adi yi a, ɛka yi ɔda woa w'nu
  Wo ara hwɛboo na di ye ɔda woa'nu
  Hwɛboo sɔfo yegyi woa wo ho
  Ɔsie ɔyɛ American ne Muslim, ɔnom bibiabi
  Nkurofo w'adi yi ɔda woa w'nu
  Hwɛ, ɛhu Christian, ɛhu Muslim, ɛhu nkaefo no Ɛhu sɔfo, ɛhu komfo basaa
  Kataasihyɛ, prɔyɛ, bɔ na ɔhyɛ nso wa nyɛ MP wo kurom kwan no nsu tɔ a pakyaa
  Obia sie ɔyɛ bad man
  Ɛno nti lecturer pɛ sɛ ɔno wo da
  Ansaa na wa ma wo pass mark
  For money we go shed blood
  Nyame bɛ yɛ, ɔbɛ kye, yɛ ntum, yɛ pɛ no fast fast
  Nti (so) fast life, fast cars, fast trap pot
  Church service hɔ na yɛ hu snap chat calls
  31st ɔwo church, ɔdi ne ho a ma Nyame
  On the 3rd na w'gye no ho kɔ Trek
  Part time Christian, you want fight full time devil
  You dey joke

Things Fall Apart by Kofi Kinata

Chorus]
Nti Nyame som paa na yɛ le som yi a?
Nyame som paa na yɛ le som yi a?
Nti Nyame som paa na yɛ le som yi a?
Nyame som paa na yɛ le som yi a?

Things Fall Apart by Kofi Kinata(English version)

Friday is all night in the chapel
Saturday we all go to the club
We are mixing up the drinks in the glass
Cos the ship that brought the Bible
People say is the same that brought the schnapp
So the girls that attended the church service
Were the same that turned up at the club

Things Fall Apart by Kofi Kinata(English version)

Is this Christianity (true worship)?
Ask your neighbor
And ask yourself as well
Is this Christianity (true worship)?
When Jehovah's Witnesses appear
You run to hide
Is this Christianity (true worship)?
Unrepentant side-chick
Is this Christianity (true worship)?
Tenant trying to usurp a landlord

Things Fall Apart by Kofi Kinata(English version)

On judgment day when God appears physically
He would have to lower His standards
Else no soul will make it to heaven
Because the pastors are refusing to preach the truth
The demand for money
Is preventing the poor from attending the church
It's like Things Fall Apart
When you complain they retort
"Don't touch my anointed"
The churches have schools
But the members are unable to afford them

Things Fall Apart by Kofi Kinata(English version)

Is this Christianity (true worship)?
Ask your neighbor
And ask yourself as well
Is this Christianity (true worship)?
The needy is made miserable
Is this Christianity (true worship)?
You never forgive your offenders
Is this Christianity (true worship)?
"Drink but don't get drunk"
You've turned it into bottles full of 'bitters'

Things Fall Apart by Kofi Kinata(English version)

Imam stop worrying yourself
The people are still drinking
I have observed that Abu is still boozing
Imam stop worrying yourself
He says he is an American Muslim
So he smokes weed and steals
There is no difference between the Christian and Muslim
Nor the pastor and the traditional priest
It's a total mess
Corruption, decadence, unfulfilled promises
MP the road to your village is un-motorable when it rains
Everyone wants to be bad
So the lecturer wants sexual favours
Before you pass his course
Others shed blood for money
God can help but He is slow; we can't wait
We want it fast-fast
So fast life, fast car, fast track court

Things Fall Apart by Kofi Kinata(English version)

In the church we see snapchat godesses
31st December she is in church
Dedicating her life to God
3rd January she is back on trek

Part-time Christian, you want to fight full time devil
You are joking!

Is this Christianity (true worship)?

Analysis

Martin King Arthur popularly known as **Kofi Kinaata** is a Ghanaian musician and songwriter from Takoradi. He is noted for his Fante rap and freestyle and therefore known as the Fante Rap God (FRG).Apart from his rap prowess, he has grown into a very good singer taking the highlife genre by storm. Kofi Kinaata was born on the 15th of April 1990 and raised in Effiakuma. Effiakuma is a residential town in the Western Region of Ghana. He attended Nana Brempong Yaw School and completed his secondary education at the Takoradi Technical Institute.

Analysis

Subject matter: religion and chaos

Themes: The theme of moral decadence as a canker in the Ghanaian society

The theme of corruption as a weakness in the Ghanaian society in the society

The mad rush for material wealth/the worship of money in place of God

Thus moral decadence and corruption are deeply entrenched in all the sections of the society. Pastors, traditional chief priests, Imams, Members of Parliament, lecturers and church goers and Moslems are all corrupt. They see moral decadence as something that is normal and even advance reasons to support both corruption and moral decadence. That is why the artiste argues that unless God lowers His standards on judgment day, nobody will make it to heaven. The language is simple and straight forward and the issues raised are contemporary issues in Ghana. These are issues that concern all sections of the Ghanaian population: the youth, the aged, the Christians, Moslems, traditionalists, academics, politicians etc. The conclusion is that we cannot fight full time devil by being a part-time Christian, Moslem or traditionalist. We need to take our religion seriously and let the word of God reflect in our daily activities and interactions with one another.

THINGS FALL APART BY KINAATA__*Language*

Obviously, the poem is set in Ghana and issues raised in the poem first of all pertain to Ghana before they can be extended to other African countries. Allusions of different kinds(historical, Biblical, literary) have been used to address issues in the poem. The title of the song is a literary allusion to both Achebe's work and to Yeats poem "The Second Coming". The origin of the title of the song can therefore be traced to Yeats. A rhetorical question which has been turned into a refrain is also worth noting in the poem. As a device that can be analysed both as a refrain and a rhetorical question, it adds a loaded meaning and function to the poem. Thus, the question does not demand immediate answers but it is meant to prick the conscience of listeners and to give them something to ponder over. The repetitive use of the question in the form of a refrain also emphasizes meaning and provides rhythm at the same time. Besides, the subject matter of the poem is embedded in this line of the song

THINGS FALL APART BY KINAATA__*Language*

Other devices such as apostrophe(*Imam stop worrying yourself*), sound devices such as alliteration(*So fast life, fast car, fast track court*), assonance (*Abu is still boozing*) have all been used to highlight issues in the poem.

Drama

Drama is usually written for the stage. A play is usually divided into acts and scenes and there are actors or dramatis personae who act out the play on stage. Stage directions are usually given to enable anyone who wants to stage the play to be able to do so.

Drama has been traditionally divided into tragedy, comedy and tragi-comedy. In tragedy, there must be a tragic hero who has the qualities of a tragic hero so that when falls, it excites pity and fear in us bringing about catharsis. Aristotle gives the best definition and description of tragedy in his book The Poetics. In tragedy, there is no poetic justice and both the language and subject matter of tragedy are serious. On the other hand, there is always poetic justice in comedy and the language and subject matter of comedy are not like those in tragedy. There is good measure of humour in comedy and there is also the use of wit in comedy. In between comedy and tragedy, we have tragi-comedy. Tragedy-comedy combines the qualities of both tragedy and comedy.

Who is William Shakespeare?

The most influential writer in all of English literature, William Shakespeare was born in 1564 to a successful middle-class glove-maker in Stratford-upon-Avon, England. Shakespeare attended grammar school, but his formal education proceeded no further. In 1582 he married an older woman, Anne Hathaway, and had three children with her. Around 1590 he left his family behind and traveled to London to work as an actor and playwright. Public and critical acclaim quickly followed, and Shakespeare eventually became the most popular playwright in England and part-owner of the Globe Theater. His career bridged the reigns of Elizabeth I (ruled 1558–1603) and James I (ruled 1603–1625), and he was a favorite of both monarchs. Indeed, James granted Shakespeare's company the greatest possible compliment by bestowing upon its members the title of King's Men. Wealthy and renowned, Shakespeare retired to Stratford and died in 1616 at the age of fifty-two. At the time of Shakespeare's death, literary luminaries such as Ben Jonson hailed his works as timeless.

Shakespeare’s works

Shakespeare’s works were collected and printed in various editions in the century following his death, and by the early eighteenth century his reputation as the greatest poet ever to write in English was well established. The unprecedented admiration garnered by his works led to a fierce curiosity about Shakespeare’s life, but the dearth of biographical information has left many details of Shakespeare’s personal history shrouded in mystery. Some people have concluded from this fact and from Shakespeare’s modest education that Shakespeare’s plays were actually written by someone else—Francis Bacon and the Earl of Oxford are the two most popular candidates—but the support for this claim is overwhelmingly circumstantial, and the theory is not taken seriously by many scholars.

Shakespeare's works

In the absence of credible evidence to the contrary, Shakespeare must be viewed as the author of the thirty-seven plays and 154 sonnets that bear his name. The legacy of this body of work is immense. A number of Shakespeare's plays seem to have transcended even the category of brilliance, becoming so influential as to affect profoundly the course of Western literature and culture ever after.

Much Ado About Nothing_ PLOT

Leonato, a kindly, respectable nobleman, lives in the idyllic Italian town of Messina. Leonato shares his house with his lovely young daughter, Hero, his playful, clever niece, Beatrice, and his elderly brother, Antonio (who is Beatrice's father). As the play begins, Leonato prepares to welcome some friends home from a war. The friends include Don Pedro, a prince who is a close friend of Leonato, and two fellow soldiers: Claudio, a well-respected young nobleman, and Benedick, a clever man who constantly makes witty jokes, often at the expense of his friends. Don John, Don Pedro’s illegitimate brother, is part of the crowd as well. Don John is sullen and bitter, and makes trouble for the others.

Much Ado About Nothing_ PLOT

When the soldiers arrive at Leonato's home, Claudio quickly falls in love with Hero. Meanwhile, Benedick and Beatrice resume the war of witty insults that they have carried on with each other in the past. Claudio and Hero pledge their love to one another and decide to be married. To pass the time in the week before the wedding, the lovers and their friends decide to play a game. They want to get Beatrice and Benedick, who are clearly meant for each other, to stop arguing and fall in love. Their tricks prove successful, and Beatrice and Benedick soon fall secretly in love with each other. But Don John has decided to disrupt everyone's happiness. He has his companion Borachio make love to Margaret, Hero's serving woman, at Hero's window in the darkness of the night, and he brings Don Pedro and Claudio to watch.

Much Ado About Nothing_ PLOT

Believing that he has seen Hero being unfaithful to him, the enraged Claudio humiliates Hero by suddenly accusing her of lechery on the day of their wedding and abandoning her at the altar. Hero's stricken family members decide to pretend that she died suddenly of shock and grief and to hide her away while they wait for the truth about her innocence to come to light. In the aftermath of the rejection, Benedick and Beatrice finally confess their love to one another. Fortunately, the night watchmen overhear Borachio bragging about his crime. Dogberry and Verges, the heads of the local police, ultimately arrest both Borachio and Conrad, another of Don John's followers. Everyone learns that Hero is really innocent, and Claudio, who believes she is dead, grieves for her.

Much Ado About Nothing_ PLOT

Leonato tells Claudio that, as punishment, he wants Claudio to tell everybody in the city how innocent Hero was. He also wants Claudio to marry Leonato's "niece"—a girl who, he says, looks much like the dead Hero. Claudio goes to church with the others, preparing to marry the mysterious, masked woman he thinks is Hero's cousin. When Hero reveals herself as the masked woman, Claudio is overwhelmed with joy. Benedick then asks Beatrice if she will marry him, and after some arguing they agree. The joyful lovers all have a merry dance before they celebrate their double wedding.

THEMES

The theme of deception/gullibility

The theme of honour/chastity

The theme of love